

The Certification Process

How certification works, and how ABS prepares you for it — from first conversation to certificate and beyond.

Overview

Certification is carried out by an independent, accredited certification body, following the route defined by ISO/IEC 17021-1: a Stage 1 audit, a Stage 2 audit, a certification decision, then regular surveillance. ABS prepares you for that audit in five steps and supports you through it. For most organisations under 200 employees, the journey from kick-off to certificate is around 10–14 weeks.

How ABS prepares you — five steps

01 Discovery & scope definition

We understand your business, customer requirements, applicable standards, certification goals and timelines, and send a fixed-price proposal within 24 hours. Nothing else begins until you are comfortable with the scope and cost.

02 Gap assessment & roadmap

We assess your current systems, controls and documentation against the selected standard and identify priorities, gaps and required actions.

03 Implementation & control strengthening

Our consultants help develop and implement practical policies, processes, controls and evidence aligned with your actual business operations.

04 Audit readiness & pre-assessment

We review implementation, verify evidence, conduct readiness checks and help your team prepare confidently for the independent certification audit.

05 Independent audit & certification support

We coordinate and support you through the independent audit, help address any findings and guide you through to successful completion.

The independent certification audit

Stage 1 audit

The certification body reviews your documentation, scope and readiness, and surfaces any gaps early. Often conducted remotely.

Stage 2 audit

The certification body's auditor gathers evidence across your operations — interviews, records and observation — to confirm the system works in practice.

Certification & surveillance

Once any findings are closed, the certification body makes an independent certification decision and issues your certificate, which carries the recognition of that body's accreditation. Surveillance audits (typically annual) and a recertification audit at the end of the three-year cycle keep it current.